

'A MILLION USES' Drone use has skyrocketed, and they are now used in crop spraying to land surveys to maintenance of powerlines, oil pipelines and even against locust swarms









spraying, a frontier that's primed for an unmanned makeover. Other uses, like mapping and survey, have already had a headstart—a year ago, the National Highways Authority of India made monthly drone surveys mandatory to monitor its highways for progress reports and maintenance. The Indian Railways too has been deploying drones for surveys and bridge inspections. "You pick up any sector and drones can impact them," says Smit Shah, president, Drone Federation of India (DFI), which represents 200 companies and 2,000 drone pilots in the country. Of course, the complexity varies depending on the uses and air space management is a critical part of that.

Shah points to Project Sanjeevani, a pilot project for a flight corridor between the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS) in New Delhi and its extension campus in Jhajjar, some 50 km by road which currently takes 1.5-2 hours. A drone would take less than half the time, even via the circuitous route around the two aerodromes on the flight